



BREASTFEEDING: MORE THAN FEEDING A BABY



INTRODUCTION

Breastfeeding simply refers to feeding a baby with breast milk. But it is more than just providing food to a baby. It is an important part of giving infants a healthy start in life, especially during the first six months, when exclusive breastfeeding is strongly recommended.

So, what exactly is exclusive breastfeeding?



WHAT IS BREASTFEEDING?



EXCLUSIVE BREASTFEEDING

Exclusive breastfeeding is the process of giving a baby only breast milk, without adding any form of water or food. The exceptions include oral rehydration solution (ORS), or drops and syrups containing vitamins, minerals or medicines.

Exclusive breastfeeding should be done for the first six months of life. According to the World Health Organization, after six months, the baby should be introduced to adequate and nutritious complementary foods to help meet their increasing nutritional needs and support healthy growth and development.

This does not mean we have to stop breastfeeding once the baby is six months old. Instead, the baby should be given complementary foods in addition to breast milk. Breastfeeding should continue alongside these foods, and WHO recommends continuing breastfeeding up to two years or beyond.



WHO RECOMMENDATION

The World Health Organization recommends: Exclusive breastfeeding for the first six months of life, followed by continued breastfeeding up to two years or beyond, with the introduction of safe, adequate and nutritious complementary foods from six months.



WHY THE FIRST SIX MONTHS MATTER



Exclusive breastfeeding provides all the nutrients an infant needs during the first six months of life. During this period, the baby is experiencing rapid growth and development, making adequate nutrition particularly important and at that point, and breast milk provides all the nutrients the baby needs during this period.



Infants who are not exclusively breastfed during the first six months may face an increased risk of certain health challenges, including diarrhoea and common childhood illnesses such as pneumonia. Breastfeeding also provides important protection against infections and supports healthy growth and brain development.



This is why the first six months matter. Exclusive breastfeeding is not just about feeding a baby; it is an important part of giving a child a healthy start in life.

THE BREASTFEEDING JOURNEY



BIRTH

Start breastfeeding within the first hour of birth.



0-6 MONTHS

EXCLUSIVE BREASTFEEDING

Only breast milk (no water or food), except ORS, vitamins, minerals or medicines.



6 MONTHS-2 YEARS+

BREASTFEEDING + COMPLEMENTARY FEEDING

Introduce safe and nutritious foods while continuing breastfeeding up to two years or beyond.



COMMON BREASTFEEDING MYTHS



✗ MYTH 1:

Babies need water in addition to breast milk during the first six months.



✓ FACT:

It is a well-known myth among adults that babies need water to aid digestion after breastfeeding, with the excuse that adults drink water after eating to aid digestion.

But this should not be the case for babies. Breast milk already contains enough water and other essential nutrients that are easily absorbed and digested by a growing baby.

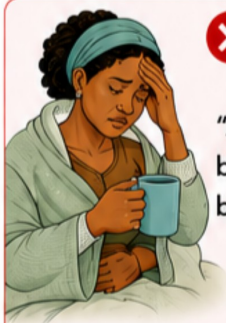
For the first six months, babies do not need additional water, even on hot days. Breast milk provides the water and nutrients they need during this period.

So, rather than giving baby water after breastfeeding, continue breastfeeding as needed..



✗ MYTH 2:

"A mother cannot breastfeed if she becomes sick."



✓ FACT:

Some families are always scared of allowing a mother to breastfeed her baby when she is sick, especially when it seems serious, fearing that it might harm the mother or that the baby might not get adequate nutrients from the breast milk produced.

But this is not always the case. Breast milk contains antibodies and other protective components that help support the baby's developing immune system. In many cases, a sick mother can continue breastfeeding her baby while taking proper care of her health and following appropriate hygiene precautions.

However, a mother who is sick should speak with a healthcare professional to know what is safe for her and her baby. Being sick does not automatically mean breastfeeding has to stop.



✗ MYTH 3:

Many mothers can't produce enough milk.



✓ FACT:

With the right support, almost all mothers can produce enough milk for their baby. The production of breast milk depends largely on how often and effectively the baby feeds from the breast. The more frequently the baby feeds, the more signals the body receives to produce breast milk..



✗ MYTH 4:

Breastfeeding beyond one year makes babies too attached to breast milk



✓ FACT:

Some people assume that a 2-year-old baby is already grown and has become used to the taste of breast milk, so it will be difficult to stop the baby from wanting breast milk after two years.

This is a common misconception. Babies and mothers are different, and there is no evidence that breastfeeding for more than a year makes it harder to stop breastfeeding.

In fact, there are more benefits to continuing breastfeeding up to two years or beyond. Breast milk continues to provide important nutrients and protection against infections as the child grows. WHO recommends continuing breastfeeding alongside adequate complementary foods up to two years or beyond.



✗ MYTH 5:

You should wash your nipples before breastfeeding.



✓ FACT:

Washing the nipples before every breastfeeding session is not necessary. The breast and nipple area have a natural scent and microbiome that the baby is already familiar with from birth.

Therefore, there is no need to wash the nipples before every feed. Regular bathing and normal hygiene are enough.





WHAT MOTHERS ACTUALLY NEED

Breastfeeding isn't the mother's job alone. To support adequate and nutritious breast milk production, breastfeeding mothers need a supportive environment where they can breastfeed comfortably, whether at home or at work.



Good nutrition, encouragement, and emotional support from family members and partners cannot be overemphasised, as these can help mothers breastfeed with confidence and continue breastfeeding successfully.



It is also important for breastfeeding mothers to get adequate rest so their bodies can recover, especially after childbirth, while caring for their babies.



Supporting a mother is one of the best ways to support successful breastfeeding.



HOW FATHERS CAN HELP

A father's support can make a big difference in a mother's breastfeeding journey. Having an involved and supportive partner can encourage a mother to breastfeed her baby adequately, whether through exclusive breastfeeding during the first six months or continued breastfeeding afterward.



Support the mother during feeding:

Help by bringing the baby to the mother when needed or by getting her items such as water, a pillow, or any other essentials so she can breastfeed comfortably.



Help care for the baby:

Taking care of the baby after breastfeeding, such as burping, changing diapers, or soothing the baby back to sleep, gives the mother time to rest and recover.



Provide encouragement and emotional support:

Some mothers may experience pain or difficulties, especially during the early stages of breastfeeding. Words of encouragement, patience, and emotional support can help boost the mother's confidence and motivate her to continue breastfeeding.



Encourage continued breastfeeding:

Reminding the mother of the importance of long-term breastfeeding and supporting the mother to continue breastfeeding alongside complementary feeding after six months up to two years or beyond, as recommended by the **World Health Organization**. This can help keep her motivated throughout the breastfeeding journey.



WHO RECOMMENDATION

The World Health Organization recommends:

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IMPORTANCE OF BREASTFEEDING

Breastfeeding offers many benefits to both the baby and the mother. Some of these include:



It helps build the baby's immune system, providing antibodies that help protect against infections and illnesses.



It strengthens the bond between the mother and her baby, creating comfort, security and emotional connection.



It helps reduce the risk of common childhood illnesses, such as diarrhoea and respiratory infections.



It supports healthy growth and brain development, laying a strong foundation for learning and overall development.



Overall, breast milk is the best source of nutrition for babies during the first six months of life, providing all the nutrients they need for healthy growth and development.



DID YOU KNOW?

Breast milk is nature's first vaccine and a mother's first gift.



NGHI RECOMMENDATION



Although it is not compulsory, NGHI recommends that expectant mothers receive breastfeeding education during pregnancy. This may include speaking with a lactation consultant or a qualified healthcare professional to better prepare for breastfeeding.



After delivery, seek professional help if you experience persistent pain while breastfeeding, your baby has difficulty latching or repeatedly refuses to breastfeed, or you notice signs of a breast infection such as redness, swelling, severe pain or fever.



Seeking help is not a sign of failure, seeking early can make breastfeeding easier and help address challenges before they become more serious.



As we commemorate World Breastfeeding Week 2026, let us continue to support, encourage and empower every mother to give her baby the best possible start.

“Supporting breastfeeding means supporting mothers.”



World Breastfeeding Week 2026

Theme:

“Breastfeeding for a sustainable start in life: Strengthen what works.”

